

flea

NEWS 96 November 2025



FLEA NEWS is a twice-yearly newsletter about fleas (Siphonaptera). Before including in publications any of the citations given here, please review for accuracy and correct formatting. Many of our sources are abstracting journals and current literature sources, and editors have not necessarily checked citations.

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Announcements

Artificial Dogs Need New Homes

I have two of Jay Georgi's "Artificial Dogs" that are in need of new laboratories to carry on a long legacy of in vitro flea evaluations. I have all the accessories, feeders, flea separator, cages of several sizes for both a 36 feeder system and a 104 feeder system. Both systems are fully operational and the price is negotiable.

Bill Donahue, Ph.D. President/Executive Director, Sierra Research Laboratories, Inc. P.O. Box 576886 5100 Parker Road Modesto, CA 95357, Email: bill@sierraresearchlaboratories.com Website: www.sierraresearchlaboratories.com

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Updated Lewis World Flea List

Siphonaptera in GBIF Secretariat (2023). GBIF Backbone Taxonomy. Checklist dataset <https://doi.org/10.15468/39omei> accessed via GBIF.org on 2025-11-18.

Hastriter, M. W., & Bossard, R. L. (2025). Robert E. Lewis World Species Flea (Siphonaptera) List (version 3.0). In O. Bánki, Y. Roskov, M. Döring, G. Ower, D. R. Hernández Robles, C. A. Plata Corredor, T. Stjernegaard Jeppesen, A. Örn, T. Pape, D. Hobern, S. Garnett, H. Little, R. E. DeWalt, J. Miller, T. Orrell, R. Aalbu, J. Abbott, C. Abreu, A. Acero P, et al., Catalogue of Life (2025-11-16 XR). Catalogue of Life Foundation, Amsterdam, Netherlands. <https://doi.org/10.48580/dgvbl-48fy>

Eckerlin Mammalian Parasitology Award

"I asked many of you if you would be interested in supporting an award through the American Society of Mammalogists (ASM) to support graduate student mammalian parasite research to honor

our friend, colleague, and mentor, Ralph Eckerlin. I have wonderful news! The ASM Board of Directors has approved this new award and we are now accepting donations.

Award information can be found here: <https://www.mammalsociety.org/committees/eckerlin-mammalian-parasitology-award>

The donation page is here: <https://asm.wildapricot.org/Donate>

You do not need to be a member of ASM to donate. Simply scroll down and enter your information, and under "Donation Type" select "Eckerlin Mammalian Parasitology Award". Please do not feel obligated to donate. But do please share this information broadly to anyone who think may be interested and able in donating. Dr. Jessica E. Light (she/her/hers), Professor and Curator of Mammals, Department of Ecology and Conservation Biology, Biodiversity Research and Teaching Collections, Texas A&M University, College Station, TX 77843, <https://lightjessica.weebly.com>

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Obituary

Dr. Lane Douglas Foil

June 16, 1949 - June 22, 2025

<https://obituaries.theadvocate.com/obituary/lane-foil-1092955302>

Partial list of Refereed Publications, Book Chapters, and invited contributions (not including patents, state and extension pubs) (<https://www.lsuagcenter.com/profiles/lfoil>):

Foil, L.D. and T. Orihel. 1975. *Dirofilaria immitis* (Leidy, 1856) in the beaver, *Castor canadensis*. J. Parasitol. 61: 433.

Foil, L.D., J.L. Frazier, and B.R. Norment. 1979. Partial characterization of lethal and neuroactive components of the brown recluse spider, (*Loxosceles reclusa*) venom. Toxicon. 17: 347-354.

Foil, L.D., L.B. Coons, and B.R. Norment. 1979. Ultrastructure of the venom gland of the brown recluse spider, *Loxosceles reclusa* Gertsch and Mulaik (Araneae: Loxoscelidae). Int. J. Insect Morphol. & Embryol. 8: 325-334.

Foil, L.D. and B.R. Norment. 1979. Envenomation by *Loxosceles reclusa*: Review article. J. Med. Entomol. 16: 18-25.

Foil, L.D., H.W. Chambers, and B.R. Norment. 1980. *Loxosceles reclusa* venom component toxicity and interaction in *Musca domestica*. Toxicon. 18: 112-117.

Norment, B.R. and L.D. Foil. 1980. Histopathology and physiological action of venom from the brown recluse spider, *Loxosceles reclusa*. In Natural Toxins, Ed. Eaker and Wadstrom. Pergamon Press, N.Y. pp. 69-76.

Foil, L.D., H.W. Chambers, R.S. Stinson, and B. Glick. 1980. Immunological aspects of trio-o-totyl phosphate induced neurotoxicity in chickens. Toxic. Appl. Pharmacol. 56: 259- 264.

Foil, L.D., C.J. Issel, W.V. Adams, and C.L. Meek. 1983. Mechanical transmission of equine infectious anemia by deer flies (*Chrysops*) and stable flies (*Stomoxys calcitrans*). Am. J. Vet. Res. 44: 155-156.

Foil, L.D. 1983. A mark-recapture method for measuring effects of spatial separation of horses on tabanid (Diptera) movement between hosts. J. Med. Entomol. 20: 301-305.

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Issel, C.J. and L.D. Foil. 1984. Studies on equine infectious anemia virus transmission by insects. J.

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- Foil, L.D., D. Satterlee, and L. Jacobs-Perry. 1985. Increased serum corticosterone levels in triorthotolyl phosphate-treated chickens. Bull. Environ. Cont. Toxicol. 34: 780-786.
- Issel, C.J., W.V. Adams, Jr., and L.D. Foil. 1985. Prospective study of the progeny of inapparent equine carriers of equine infectious anemia virus. Am. J. Vet. Res. 46: 1114-1116.
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Tang, S., Chen, L., Wu, J., Chen, B., Liu, S., Duan, M., ... & Yang, X. Mitogenomic architecture and phylogenetic placement of *Ctenophthalmus yunnanus* and *Frontopsylla diqingensis*: insights from comparative genomics. *Frontiers in Veterinary Science*, 12, 1683581.

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Zurita, A., & Matthee, C. A. (2025). A molecular phylogeny of Ceratophyllomorpha (Insecta: Siphonaptera): geographical distribution, origins, and host associations. *Zoological Journal of the Linnean Society*, 204(3), zlaf042. From a taxonomic and systematic perspective, the order Siphonaptera is a neglected and overlooked group of insects. The classification of fleas is further hampered by a few classical taxonomic keys published over 40 years ago and, in many cases, they are not digitized and thus not easily accessible. More recently, molecular data have been utilized with great success in an attempt to resolve some of the higher level taxonomic uncertainties for Siphonaptera, but detailed phylogenetic studies of fleas are still scarce. Here we conduct a comprehensive phylogenetic and evolutionary review using 148 taxa within the infraorder Ceratophyllomorpha with 4689 aligned sites derived from seven different molecular markers. Bayesian phylogenetic analyses supported the monophyly of 34/48 genera (71%), and also supported the monophyly of most members within the Leptopsyllidae, Ceratophyllidae, and Ischnopsyllidae. The dated phylogeny constructed shows that diversification within the Ceratophyllomorpha dates back to ~23.1 Mya, and from this period onwards, the evolution of the fleas included herein was influenced by both host association and host distribution. The most common hosts of the Ceratophyllomorpha group were various families of rodents, with the exception of the Ischnopsyllidae, that was specific to the order Chiroptera. The rich extant Ceratophyllomorpha diversity is mainly confined to the Palaearctic region, and this geographic pattern was most evident for the family Leptopsyllidae. The present study emphasizes the need for a comprehensive taxonomic revision for the order Siphonaptera. Since the current taxonomic schemes are mainly based on morphology, future focus should be given to those species where no molecular data are available and where molecular data are scarce.

[Editor's note: paper concludes that bat fleas are paraphyletic, not monophyletic as previous research found.]

Conservation

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Russo, L. (2025). Roadside Surveys as a Method for Nonlethal Insect Monitoring. *Psyche: A Journal of Entomology*, 2025(1), 8881730. Insects are a megadiverse group of organisms, which makes them difficult to survey without large, lethal collections. At the same time, we have increasing concerns about declines in insect biomass and diversity, which could have serious implications for ecosystem functioning. Current methods of insect monitoring are high in cost and labor and expertise intensive, often requiring large amounts of physical storage space that must be maintained indefinitely, making them difficult to sustain to the degree and extent that would be required to track population level changes in insect species at local or regional scales. Traditional methods can also be slow, sometimes requiring years to process and identify all the specimens collected. Moreover, there are concerns about the potential role of destructive sampling methods in exacerbating already declining groups of insects. Due to this, nonlethal, sustainable, rapid, and low-cost methods of monitoring and surveying are needed. I combined modern technological methods, including photographic vouchers and community science programs (i.e., iNaturalist), and surveys of insect roadkill to test as a potential nonlethal method of monitoring insect populations. I repeated these surveys on a weekly basis under appropriate weather conditions along a highway bridge for the duration of a year and recorded 4917 specimens with 3061 specimens (62.2%) identified to 152 species, and an additional 1506 (30.6%) to 111 genera. I found this method promising for nonlethal monitoring because photographic vouchers required less time and space to use and maintain, and using the expertise of community scientists lowered initial barriers to participation. This method also had a rapid turnaround time and was straightforward to repeat without adding significant bias. The roadkill surveys avoided additional insect mortality as they involved insects that had already been killed by vehicular traffic.

Hosts and Distribution

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based on a literature review as well as our own data. They are as follows: *Myodopsylla trisellis*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*Ischnopsyllus*) *dolosus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *elongatus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *intermedius*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *plumatus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *needhami*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *obscurus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *octactenus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *simplex*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *variabilis*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*Hexactenopsylla*) *hexactenus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*H.*) *petropolitanus*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*H.*) *ussuriensis*, *Ischnopsyllus* (*H.*) *comans*, *Nycteridopsylla pentactena*, *Nycteridopsylla longiceps*, *Nycteridopsylla eusarca*, *Rhinolophopsylla unipunctinatus unipunctinatus*. *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *elongatus* and *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *octactenus* were recorded in Kaluga Region and Vladimir Region for the first time. *Ischnopsyllus* (*I.*) *variabilis* in Kaluga Region is a newly documented find. Studied bat flea fauna exhibits a distinctly Western Palearctic appearance.

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Shohana, N. N., Hossain, M. S., Labony, S. S., Ali, M. H., Alim, M. A., Nandi, A. K., & Anisuzzaman. (2025). The First Report on Cat Flea (*Ctenocephalides felis*), a Zoonotic Haematophagous Insect Infestation in Humans in Bangladesh: A Case Report and Literature Review. *Veterinary Medicine and Science*, 11(6), e70637.

Tammsoo, C. (2025). Lüljalgsed linnupesades suluspesitsevate värvuliste näitel. Publisher Eesti Maaülikool, <http://hdl.handle.net/10492/9888>. Bird nests constitute a narrow yet biologically rich ecological niche. In addition to avian occupants, cavity nests are frequently inhabited by a diverse assemblage of arthropods. The aim of this study was to provide, for the first time in Estonia, a comprehensive and evidence-based overview of arthropod communities in the nests of cavity-nesting passerines. Two hypotheses guided the study: (1) fleas (Siphonaptera) represent the dominant group of parasites in cavity-nesting bird nests; (2) due to differences in nest structure, tit species (Paridae) harbour higher flea abundances than other taxa. In total, 80 nests were collected from eight sites across Estonia in late summer 2024, after fledglings had vacated the nests. Arthropods were primarily extracted using a Tullgren funnel apparatus. To verify the effectiveness of this method, material from selected nests was additionally hand-sorted. The Tullgren funnel yielded an average extraction efficiency of 73% for all arthropods and 48% specifically for fleas. Altogether, 7,021 arthropod individuals representing 13 taxonomic groups/orders were recorded. The most abundant group was the Siphonaptera, with 1,566 individuals, all belonging to a single species—the hen flea (*Ceratophyllus gallinae* (Schrank, 1803)). During the study, a national checklist of Estonian flea species was compiled, comprising 37 species. Flea abundance was highest in the nests of the great tit (*Parus major*) and the common starling (*Sturnus vulgaris*), with the most heavily infested nest being one sequentially occupied by the great tit (*Parus major*) and later by the pied flycatcher (*Ficedula hypoleuca*). The results support previous findings regarding the dominance of fleas in cavity-nesting bird nests; however, earlier studies reported greater flea species diversity. This thesis provides a valuable baseline for future investigations into bird nest arthropod communities, both in Estonia and more broadly. Future research in Estonia should explore the relationship between nest construction material and arthropod abundance and diversity over broader spatial and temporal scales.

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Российский паразитологический журнал, 19(3), 298-304.[Fauna of blood-sucking arthropods of the family Gamasoidea, mouse-like rodents of the Volgograd region of the Volga-Akhtuba floodplain]

ЗВЕРОХОЗЯЙСТВАХ, Э. П. З. В., & ТВЕРСКОЙ, О. ФЕДЕРАЛЬНОЕ ГОСУДАРСТВЕННОЕ БЮДЖЕТНОЕ ОБРАЗОВАТЕЛЬНОЕ УЧРЕЖДЕНИЕ ВЫСШЕГО ОБРАЗОВАНИЯ «САНКТ-ПЕТЕРБУРГСКИЙ ГОСУДАРСТВЕННЫЙ УНИВЕРСИТЕТ ВЕТЕРИНАРНОЙ МЕДИЦИНЫ»(ФГБОУ ВО СПбГУВМ).2025. [ECTOPARASITOSIS OF FUR-BEARING ANIMALS IN FUR FARMSTVER REGION (EPIZOOTOLOGY AND CONTROL MEASURES)]Thesis for an academic degree, Candidate of Veterinary Sciences, ST. PETERSBURG STATE UNIVERSITYVETERINARY MEDICINE.

Кондратьев, Е. Н., Сажнев, А. С., & Аникин, В. В. (2025). Распределение членистоногих в норе и гнезде береговой ласточки (*Riparia riparia* (Linnaeus, 1758))(Aves: Passeriformes) на Севере Нижнего Поволжья. Экосистемы, (41), 106-119.[Distribution of arthropods in the burrow and nest of *Riparia riparia* (Linnaeus, 1758)) (Aves: Passeriformes) in the North of the Lower Volga region]

МЕДВЕДЕВ, С., ВЕРЖУЦКИЙ, Д., & КОТТИ, Б. (2025). Учредители: Российская академия наук. ПАРАЗИТОЛОГИЯ, 59(3), 179-214.[SPECIES OF FLEAS (SIPHONAPTERA) - CARRIERS OF PLAGUE IN NATURAL CENTERS OF THE WORLD (PART 1, MEDVEDEV S.G.1, VERZHUTSKY D.B.2, COTTI B.K.3]

Овсянникова, А. В. Малышева Наталья Семеновна.Abstract: The ecological features of the spread of fleas (Insecta Siphonaptera) in the Kursk region are related to factors affecting the spread of these insects, including climatic conditions, biological characteristics of hosts, anthropogenic factors and other aspects of the environment. www.flagmannauki.ru

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明尾亮佑, 石井秀空, 千葉駿, 栗山武夫, & 山崎健史. (2025). 兵庫県南部のアライグマから採集されたノミ類. 人と自然, 35, 52-55.[Fleas collected from raccoons in southern Hyogo Prefecture]

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Physiology and Morphology

Calandriello, D. C., Cunha, V. A., Batista, D., & Genevcus, B. C. (2025). Genetic architecture of morphological adaptation and plasticity in insects: gaps, biases, and future directions. Current Opinion in Insect Science, 101362.[abstract in previous FN]

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Cooke, M., Chembars, M. S., & Pitts, R. J. (2025). The conserved IR75 subfamily mediates carboxylic acid detection in insects of public health and agricultural importance. *Journal of Insect Science*, 25(1), iea012. Insects perceive and respond to carboxylic acids (CAs), amines, and aldehydes primarily via conserved ionotropic receptors (IRs). These receptors form the basis for a second olfactory system distinct from the well-characterized odorant receptors. Neurons expressing IRs are housed in dedicated sensilla and innervate glomeruli, separate from those innervated by odorant receptor neurons. The IR8a co-receptor is highly conserved across insect orders and, together with ionotropic receptor tuning receptors, primarily detects CAs. The conservation of genes and the anatomical separation of neural pathways underscore the importance of these compound classes and CAs, specifically in insect chemical ecology. We provide a summary of carboxylic acid detection in insects, focusing on dipteran and lepidopteran species of significance to public health and agriculture. An overview of insect behavior toward CAs is provided, as well as a comprehensive update on carboxylic acid receptor function in insects. Phylogenetic analysis of publicly available genome databases reveals several species that encode and express homologs of previously orphaned carboxylic acid receptors, highlighting avenues for future research. ["The order Siphonaptera, ... represents an understudied group in terms of chemosensation."]

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